someone I only vaguely knew. Next to it runs the creek, its current always flowing the same way. All I can think is to walk past it, against the tide, get beyond it, away from all of it, and keep going uphill. Uphill will lead me out, no matter how tired I get. Uphill is out. Uphill is free. That is my only bread trail.

As I am walking through Torquay Avenue, I allow for the gentle incline to help me saunter beyond the neighbourhood of detached houses. I know these from the occasional drives out of Burnley, where me and my sister sit in the back and argue about the lyrics to Belinda Carlisle or Cyndi Lauper or Kate Bush or Tears for Fears tapes our parents are playing in the front. The houses are humble still, the ones we pause mid-argument to scan as we drive through, but far bigger than my 1960s semi-detached.

Then I am up Sutton Avenue, strides getting longer as I feel myself drifting out of a sadness and into more of a daydreamy solitude. I am not skiving the way I have seen it advertised. The other boys choose to do it in pool halls, smoking and drinking in groups through the day before getting hauled in; their playful, rebellious plea for attention duly noticed and landing them back at school with toothy, proud grins the same afternoon. My withdrawal is less animated, far more private. I don't want to put it on anyone, to make a show, to let anyone down. I just need to be alone. After all, the truth is I don't have anyone that would want to do this with me even if I wanted. Somehow, it feels correct to make a point of this loneliness on a pilgrimage; to justify it to myself and align how it feels inside with how I find myself outside. To be alone, inside and out.

I'm no stranger to silence. I am doing the walk as quietly as I sat in school with a broken wrist caused by a fall on black ice that dropped across Burnley two years previously. I had slipped, football bag in hand, and put my hand out to break my fall as I did. Everyone had seen it on the way to school and yet, I just picked myself up and walked on. I told no one, I just sat in class, holding it, my jaws clenched tight, until a teacher told me I looked paler than the freshly painted white wall. 'You're really sweating,' she said, alarmed, before calling my mum to take me to hospital. When I got there, it was full of people who had been taken the same way by the black ice, and still the inner humiliation did not fade. I do the walk as quietly as the time I drop a catch for Burnley CC against Burnley FC in not even two years from now. I'm on the boundary and I spill the match-